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Teen And Up Audiences

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# Princess of the Horde

by n7punk

Summary

Adora is learning how to lead the Horde and control She-ra – at least, she is trying to – but uncovering more of the operations that she is supposed to be running has her questioning her choices. She wants to change things for the better, but can she really stand by while the Horde is poisoning the land?
(Horde Lords Catradora AU)

Notes

After a rough month, I'm back with more Horde Lords!

# She-ra

When Adora agreed to Catra's plan of continuing their rise to the top of Horde so they could change it for the better, she was mostly convinced that the Princesses were somehow messing with her through Light Hope and she would discover that everything she said in the Crystal Castle was a lie. Or at least, she was hoping so. The more reports come back from Thaymor, however, the less likely that seems. Grizzlor is making good progress on setting up a base there, but he has catalogued little in the way of weapons or military supplies in the town.

There have been some, but the weapons are mostly things like simple bows and spears. The kinds of things that Adora imagines a regular civilian might be able to get their hands on to protect themselves from the Horde expanding ever closer to their home. One town being a target doesn't necessarily mean that the Horde is wrong about the Princesses being dangerous, and it could be that the Horde is still better than the Rebellion, but Adora's doubt is only growing.

She feels like there is a hole in her chest every time that she looks at Catra and remembers everything she almost had with her so many times and lost. If the Horde's top strategist could be so cruel, what hope is there for the rest of the operation that she was running? Adora knows there are good people in the Horde, but she is afraid that she won't be enough to put a stop to invasions like this, especially because Catra's proposed strategy has been to mostly play along at first while they gather intel and gain favor with Hordak.

Adora can't pretend to be okay with attacking civilians. Luckily, they aren't trying to push on at the moment, just holding their position as they redistribute their troops now that they have a foothold at the edge of the Whispering Woods. Thaymor is further than they have ever managed to advance into them before, but they are close enough to the edge that the Woods haven't magically shifted the land away – at least not far. Thaymor has

moved *some* and its cause for enough concern that they aren't trying to press forward right away.

Hordak is impatient, but he seems to be cautious of the Woods, so he is letting Adora stall. It gives her time to actually acquaint herself with their operations. Adora spends most of her days running between tasks. Every morning she has woken up in awe at having Catra in her arms and bitter about how it was taken from her before. She only gets to spend a few minutes processing that emotion before she is forced to get up to read through reports.

Luckily Catra is helping her and two eyes make the process go faster, but it isn't how Adora wants to spend time with her. It isn't helped by the fact that they aren't alone while they do so and thus can't do much to catch up on the time that they missed. Scorpia has latched onto them in an odd way and hangs around, ostensibly to help them, as they work. Adora is as grateful for it as she is perplexed by it. When she asked Catra for her opinion on it, she seemed unsure, but she shrugged and said that she thinks Scorpia doesn't have a lot of friends and wants to be needed. Adora *does* need her help.

She knows a bit about everything that Shadow Weaver did as Hordak's Second, but she doesn't know much about how to be a Force Captain. The more help she can get as she adjusts, the better. It does mean that she can't pull Catra into her lap as they go over logistics, though. One of the first things they do when they go to their room at night is wrap each other in a tight hug and kiss like the last few hours without each other's touch have been torture.

Adora would love to spend all day in contact with Catra, but when she tried to hold Catra's hand in the hallway the first day after the invasion, Catra twitched away like she had been shocked.

"Not where people can see, alright?" Catra said, her voice low as she looked away. Her ears were pinned back. The haunted look in her eye hurt Adora, but she agreed. She tried to ask about it

again that night, when they were alone in her room, but Catra flinched just like she had earlier. She said that someone might try to accuse Adora of favoritism if they found out, and that people didn't generally flaunt their bedmates in the Horde anyway, but they both knew that damage to Adora's reputation had nothing to do with keeping their affection behind closed doors.

They are more than *bedmates*. Still, it isn't like they are keeping their relationship a secret or anything. Catra has moved into her room after all. Sure, her official assignment is still their old bunk, but she hasn't been to the bunkroom for three days. They aren't keeping it a secret, though there is a legitimate argument to not being too obvious in public. Catra is right about the risks, even if memories only she has seem like the more likely reason for her hesitance. Adora will make do with what she has. They are under a lot of stress already and she doesn't need to add to it.

She is relying on Catra to keep her stable right now. She doesn't need to add more weight to her shoulders. Catra is the one going down to Shadow Weaver's cell everyday, after all. Adora hasn't been able to face her since Catra told her the truth. It makes her feel sick every time that she thinks about going down there. Catra looks into the cell to make sure that Shadow Weaver is still breathing and has enough food. Her reports back are the closest that Adora can come to handling the knotted emotions in her chest.

Catra doesn't want Adora to go down for herself. She says that Shadow Weaver tries to threaten or guilt her every time she notices her. Adora is already teetering on the edge, unsure if fixing the Horde is noble enough to justify staying here when she has so many doubts. Catra looked in her in the eyes and told her flatly that Shadow Weaver could talk her into anything. Adora tried to argue it wasn't true, but Catra cut her off.

"Adora, if you have doubts about the Horde, talking to her is the worst thing that you could do. She'll exploit any weakness. Do you want to give her the chance to talk you into doing the wrong thing? She can do it. Let me check her wounds and ignore her.

You don’t need her bullshit,” Catra argued. Adora thinks she deserves more credit than that, but she can’t deny that she *is* vulnerable right now, and one thing Shadow Weaver definitely succeeded in was teaching her not to expose her vulnerabilities to anyone.

Someone will inevitably exploit them. Shadow Weaver would happily be the one to do so. For now, Adora tries to just focus on being Second. It is enough work by itself without her goal of correcting the Horde’s path.

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“Did you see that?” Adora eagerly calls, twisting around to face the branch where Catra had been sitting the last time she looked up. Catra stomps down on a purr as she watches from the other end of the clearing. The new training sim is programmed to ignore everybody but Adora – and She-ra. None of Adora’s robotic opponents paid attention when Catra started sneaking about the simulated branches of the trees and Adora was too busy fighting to notice.

Cobalt calculated this sim specifically to force Adora into a corner. Since the Crystal Castle, she hasn’t been able to summon She-ra. She needs to practice with her to understand her. Adora said that she thinks she needs to be in some kind of danger to bring She-ra out, but she didn’t really seem to believe what she was saying. They both know that it’s bullshit. Adora summoned She-ra just to pick Catra up and annoy her back in the Whispering Woods. The stress or a lack of conviction is more likely to be her problem, but the sim might still help her overcome it.

Adora is adorable as she looks around for Catra, confused and blinking with wide eyes at the empty air where Catra was once crouched. The first wave of robots has been defeated, but there

are more to come and Adora can't afford to get distracted by Catra's vanishing act like this. Normally Catra would compliment Adora for managing to take on such a large force on her own, especially with a weapon that she has only been using for a few days, but she isn't about to give away her position.

The robots aren't the only thing in store for Adora today. Catra waits until Adora starts to turn her head, casting her vision about in search for Catra, before she leaps from the trees. Adora doesn't spot her in time to brace for the tackle and they both go rolling, Adora crying out with surprise. Catra is forced to let go so she can tuck into a tight ball and absorb her momentum with a roll, but she quickly leaps to her feet and springs for Adora again. Her claws are sheathed, but the shock on Adora's face means she likely isn't processing that.

"Catra, hey-" she starts to protest, barely making it up onto her feet before Catra descends on her again and starts wrestling her. She has only one goal: take the sword from her. Adora is going to have to get used to defending it in battle if her opponents are smart. They will be princesses, so who knows, but Catra knew to go straight for Shadow Weaver's mask when she fought her. Take away the source of your enemy's magic and suddenly the fight becomes easy. Not that Adora can't hold her own, but the power of She-ra is on another level.

"Catra, the next wave is about to start, quit messing around!" Adora chastises as they wrestle, sending Catra a glare before Catra manages to grapple onto her back. Clearly she hasn't *gotten it* yet, but the robots won't fight Catra. If Adora has to fight them both at once, that might finally force her into enough of a bind to bring She-ra out. Catra is kind of hoping that managing it once will break down whatever mental block is holding her back right now.

She likes wrestling with Adora, but she doesn't like sincerely trying to fight her. Adora seems to have realized that Catra is trying to take the sword from her now. She is holding it out at arm's length with one hand as she tries to wrestle Catra off her back with the

other. Catra has to whip her tail around wildly to keep her balance as she digs in her claws just enough to give her purchase. Her arms aren't as long as Adora's. She isn't going to be able to reach the sword from here and she can hear the robots surrounding them as they prepare for the second wave.

They might not be targeting her, but she doesn't think they will bother to try to avoid collateral damage. If they have to go through her to get to Adora, they will. Catra growls, releasing Adora quickly to do a series of flips backwards until she lands on top of one of the circling robots. She crouches down, burying her claws in its hull to fasten herself on as she watches Adora whip around and realize that she let Catra distract her until she was surrounded.

"Not funny, Catra!" Adora calls, shooting her a glare as she readies the sword in front of her. Catra throws her a lazy grin from her perch despite how she is having to lash her tail again to maintain her balance on the round hull of the robot. Her claws help, but without her tail to balance she would just slide down its sides and leave long gashes despite how the robot isn't even trying to throw her off, instead taking aim at Adora.

"You should have been paying attention, *princess*," Catra throws back. Adora lets out an indignant *hey!* before she is distracted by dodging a blast from one of the robots. Catra likes to rile Adora up, but today she is doing it in service of something. Word of She-ra has spread throughout the Horde. Adora being Shadow Weaver's ward is why Hordak picked her to be Second – although in the days since Catra has come to suspect the fact that she was simply *there* was also a factor – but the troops and other captains began treating her with respect after Thaymor. There is a very real possibility they will start treating her differently again if she doesn't master She-ra.

For a while, Adora holds her own again the robots. She seems to constantly be on the verge of getting snagged by a blast, but she manages to avoid them and take down one of the bots. She is on the run, though. This wave is too much for one person to handle

alone. Truthfully, the last one was too, but a combination of skill and luck saw her through. That isn't going to be the case this time. The bots' blasts are set to a painful shock, and though it shouldn't injure Adora, it isn't the innocent zap they normally face in training that is just enough for their equipment to mark them as hit. If Adora gets hit, it is going to hurt.

Catra watches Adora dodge and take swipes with her sword, silently urging her to transform, but Adora only raises her sword above her head once and nothing happens even when she says the passphrase. The moments' distraction leaves her open to attack. She ends up on the run after that, barely avoiding getting hit with no opening to attack for herself. Catra digs her claws in as her bot steed prowls through the trees, looking for its target again after it lost sight of Adora. A moment's reprieve isn't going to save Adora. She needs to go on the offensive, and to do that, she needs She-ra.

Catra tries to think of what Shadow Weaver would do if she were training Adora. She would probably goad Adora about how failure like this isn't an option on the battlefield. Catra can hear her voice now: *How do you expect to end this war if you can't control your own powers*? It might work in the moment, but it would only make Adora's block worse overall. That tells Catra what *not* to do, so she just needs to figure out what the opposite of Shadow Weaver's method would be.

As Adora remerges from the trees, cutting off a bot's leg and then quickly being forced to run for cover before the others converge on the threat, Catra gets an idea.

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It takes Adora a few moments to realize that Catra has vanished again. It would put her on guard if she weren't already running

ragged trying to keep up. She doesn't know why Catra has decided to join the robots – the last thing that Adora wants to do is aim She-ra at Catra, so this definitely isn't going to help her summon her – but she knows that she must have something up her sleeve if she has vanished again. Even more worryingly, suddenly all the bots fall back.

They aren't supposed to do that until their target is down. Catra vanished to have Cobalt change the sim's setting on the fly, then. That only makes Adora tenser. She doesn't know what to expect from here on out. Maybe that uncertainty will force her to access She-ra to protect herself, but right now she just feels wound tight, panting from exertion as she scans the trees for any sign of hostiles.

"For the honor of Grayskull," Adora tries again, lifting her sword about her head. It shines, giving her a flicker of hope, but then it dims again and nothing happens. She drops her hand, discouraged. She feels useless. She-ra is so powerful, she could really make a difference out on the battlefield, and Adora can't even figure out how to access her. The voice in the back of her mind tells her that she doesn't *want* to. As long as she isn't sure of her crusade, She-ra remains out of her grasp.

She should just call it at this point. She has more reports to read. She got some practice in with the sword, even if its magic remains elusive to her. Now that the parameters for this sim have been defined, she can come try it again any time that the training deck is empty. This will likely become her new afternoon routine, at least until she figures out something better, but she doesn't think she is going to muster the determination to access She-ra today-

A movement in the trees pulls her out of her thoughts. Adora whips around, looking up just in time to watch Catra drop down from the branches and land beside her. Adora immediately raises a second hand to grip the sword's hilt, ready for Catra to try to steal it from her again, but this time Catra doesn't lunge at her, instead straightening up in the center of the clearing and throwing Adora a cocky smirk.

"We're switching to phase three," she informs her. Adora winces. She can't imagine managing to stay on her feet with even more robots on her.

"It's not going to work. I can't do it," Adora admits, looking away. Her shoulders fall heavily with her words. Despite how she knows that she should be on her guard, she even lowers the sword in front of her. She started this training sim hopeful, but she just feels worse than before. She has tried to summon She-ra four times since it started and the best that she has gotten is a dull glow. She hasn't been able to turn the sword into a shield again or fire a beam from it despite knowing that it is something that she can do. She doesn't know how to use her magic.

Catra shakes her head, stepping forward towards her. That just makes it worse. It's hard enough to admit that she has failed. She can't take Catra insisting that she go on. She asked Catra to help oversee her training as She-ra because she knew that she needed an outside of perspective – being in charge of your own improvement is generally a bad idea – but she knows now would be the time that any regular instructor would push her harder and she just can't do it right now. She doesn't know how to make She-ra work when she has doubts like this.

"You don't have to. *We* can do it. I'm joining you for this one," Catra tells her, walking right past her to stand at her back, dropping into a ready stance. Adora feels her heart flutter in her chest as she processes those words. She twists her head, looking back over her shoulder to find a small smile tugging at Catra's lips as she looks back too so they can make eye contact. "It's not like you'll be alone in battle anyway. You need practice not swinging that thing into your soldiers too," Catra says, with a shrug, but there is an affection dancing in her eyes that betrays the fact this isn't for purely tactical reasons.

In the trees, Adora hears the telltale sound of robots approaching. She turns forward again, raising the sword back up into a ready position. Despite their earlier tussles, she trusts Catra to watch her back if she says she is going to. The sim is programmed to be

near-impossible for one person, but maybe two can handle it. Catra is right, anyway: she could use the practice.

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At first, it is like the second wave. They hold their own. Catra knows that they can't keep doing it, though. There are too many robots. Either Adora will transform into She-ra and end the fight, or they will eventually be overwhelmed and Cobalt will be forced to pull the plug. If it ends up being the latter, then hopefully Adora will feel a bit better after fighting together at least. She is clearly teetering on the edge of her limit.

Now is when Shadow Weaver would *push*, so instead Catra offers her hand and pulls. The absolute last thing that Shadow Weaver would do would be join the fray herself, so that is what Catra does. Besides, Adora does need to learn how to use the sword around others. Catra doesn't think that Adora is going to flail it around wildly, but practice is important. She likes fighting alongside her too, especially when no one else has the authority to reprimand them for failing to meet some invisible quota.

They have trained together for years, but despite how in sync they are in battle, the opponents are too numerous for them to keep up. Catra gets hit and yelps, unused to the sting of electricity being that strong. Normally she only gets a jolt like that from one source, and it isn't the training deck. In an instant, Adora is running to her side – they were separated and trying to flank a bot when another one took the opening to shoot Catra – but that leaves her back exposed.

Even with Catra now on the target list, Adora is a higher priority target. Two bots blast her in quick succession and she cries out. She has to fall into a forward roll to cover the full body twitch she gives in response to the hits. With Adora on the ground, Catra

becomes the highest priority target. It only lasts a few seconds before Adora springs back to her feet, but that is all that it takes in battle. Catra wasn't expecting all the robots to turn on her like that. She leaps backwards to avoid being blasted and lands within range of physical attack from one of the bots.

Adora clambers back up to her feet just in time for Catra to watch her eyes lock onto her and her expression to change to one of horror. The next second, Catra is sailing through the air after being bodied by one of the bots from behind. She manages to tuck in before she collides with one of the trees, but the impact hits her hard. She falls limp to the floor, her head ringing and entire body temporarily numb as all her nerves go into overdrive trying to determine what is hurt. For a few seconds she is treated to nothing but blackness.

Then the pain hits. The impact was harsh on her back and her neck is screaming from the whiplash of the impact. Everything is programmed to hurt, but not cause permanent injury. At the moment, that second part feels less believable as she struggles to get her arms under her and push herself up before she can be hit again. She struggles for breath, trying to open her eyes despite how all they want to do is squeeze shut from the pain. The only sound in her ears is a high whine as her blood rushes and her body continues to take stock of its injuries.

A hand scoops under her. She doesn't need to struggle up to her feet because the next thing that she knows she is being lifted and thrown over a shoulder that is far too wide for Adora's own. Catra curls around She-ra, focusing on breathing as the frantic part of her mind quiets. She doesn't need to get back on her feet. Adora will keep them out of range of the bots. Catra can actually take a moment to recover instead of throwing herself right back into the fray. Adora's movements jostle her, but the twinges it causes barely registers compared to the fading spike of the initial impact.

After several seconds of letting her body process through the pain, Catra opens her eyes. Adora is holding her in place with one hand while she swings her blade in arcs in front of her. Catra

doesn’t feel up to lifting her head, but she can see several bots left in Adora’s wake that she must have taken out while Catra was still in shock. Her ears swivel around at the sound of metal tearing behind her and then Adora goes still. Nothing moves. The only sounds are their heartbeats and the quiet whirring of broken bots trying and failing to move.

“Training exercise successfully completed,” comes the announcement over the speaker. Catra has worked through the pain enough to move without necessity again. She shifts, raising her front half up despite the twinges of pain it causes. Adora quickly shifts, bending and gently setting Catra down on her feet. Catra finds herself blinking up at She-ra. The expression of concern pinching her face is at odds with the hardened warrior that Catra saw She-ra to be the first few times Adora summoned her, but she still glows golden as she inspects Catra, cautiously running one hand down her side like she expects to feel broken bones.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, her voice anxious. Catra’s tail twitches behind her as she and Adora lock eyes. It is weird to have someone so clearly built for war fussing over her potential injuries. She-ra’s hair and cape are shifting in a nonexistent breeze, but all that magical energy is currently being directed at Catra. Catra nods despite the pain flaring in her neck.

They have all been thrown around during an exercise before. It sucks, but usually they are immediately disqualified and get to just lay there to recover. After a few moments of stillness, it’s not hard to walk off. Catra won’t deny that she feels *shitty* and she is going to be bruised tomorrow, but she has gotten worse in a training exercise before. Adora’s expression still hasn’t eased, nor has She-ra shown any signs of slipping away.

“I’m fine, Adora. I won’t be joining you for the exercise tomorrow, but I can walk,” Catra assures her. Adora is clearly not happy with that. She bends and, before Catra can stop her, scoops her up in her arms. Catra immediately flushes, her tail lashing as Adora carefully cradles her against her chest. “I can walk!” Catra

repeats, her voice embarrassingly high and flustered. It cracks in the middle. She is glad that they were training alone today so no one else is around to see this. The concern on Adora's face finally eases just so she can throw Catra an annoying grin as she begins walking towards the door.

"You shouldn't aggravate your injuries and you don't weigh anything to me like this. Let me help you, Catra. You got hurt because of me," Adora tells her, starting off cocky before sincerity creeps into her voice. Catra feels her tail twitch where it is draped over Adora's arm as they step out of the training deck. "We're done for today," Adora informs Cobalt as they pass him. Catra immediately hisses a little and turns her face away so he can't see her blush.

This is *ridiculous*, and the worst part is that she doesn't really want Adora to put her down. Being carried is kind of nice. Adora's words, however, annoy her. She would protest them, but they have ignited an idea in the back of her mind. Reluctantly, she lets Adora carry her away from the training deck and just hopes that they don't run into anyone else before they reach somewhere private and she can test out her new theory.

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They were nearly caught up on reports this morning, but Adora isn't surprised when Scorpia finds them in the hall with more files tucked under her arm. They took a break to try the training sim because Cobalt had just finished setting up the new parameters and She-ra is an important asset, but if they had been further behind it might have needed to wait. They still aren't caught up. It feels like the work generates itself faster than they can learn how to do it, but Adora knows realistically that they are just going through a learning curve right now.

She feels like she is failing every time she looks at the pile of folders and realizes it is hardly smaller, but despite how she should get right back to it, it isn't her primary concern right now. It seems to stop being Scorpia's too when she spots Catra cradled in Adora's arms. She seems to be unphased by She-ra, instead narrowing in on Catra immediately and cooing. Catra gives a flustered hiss in response and turns away, tucking her face into Adora's shoulder almost like a child. It makes Adora's chest warm as she beams at Scorpia. She is glad *someone* else appreciates how cute Catra is. She has always been alone in that.

"I will kill you with my bare hands," Catra threatens from Adora's shoulder. Adora grins as Scorpia blinks at Catra's tense form, her cheeks warming a little. Adora feels a weird possessive spike seeing Scorpia's flush. She has had some issues with possessive feelings over the last few days. Sometimes Scorpia looks at Catra in a certain way and Adora struggles to respect Catra's moratorium on public affection, wanting to make it clear that she isn't *available*. She knows she is overreacting because Scorpia occasionally looks at her the same way, but as much as she wants everybody to appreciate Catra, she also doesn't want to *share* her.

"Whatever it is has to wait. Catra got hit pretty hard. I'm taking her back to my room to lie down," Adora tells Scorpia. Catra's tail twitches against her bicep and she huffs a little into Adora's shoulder, but she doesn't correct her. Adora knows that Catra doesn't normally like to even *acknowledge* her injuries, much less let other people know about them, but no one is going to exploit her moments of weakness anymore if Adora has anything to say about it.

"Oh no! Is there anything I can do to help? I'm trained in all basic levels of first-aid," Scorpia says, her expression turning almost comically horrified. Adora shakes her head, unable to help the way her arms tighten a little around Catra, drawing her close to her chest. She knows that Scorpia isn't trying to imply that Adora wouldn't have taken care of Catra on her own. Scorpia is just worried about her new friend. Still, Adora is feeling surprisingly

possessive since they got together – or maybe it isn't surprising given how many times that she has lost this.

She doesn't need Scorpia's help taking care of *her* lover. Truthfully, Catra probably doesn't even need to be fussed over right now, but she is allowing Adora to do it, so she is eagerly taking advantage of the opportunity. She really likes being able to carry Catra so easily in this form. She knows that she should be training more with She-ra now that she has managed to summon her, but she certainly isn't going to let Catra go into another sim right now and she doesn't want to leave her alone either. As much as she would prefer that Catra never gets hurt at all, at least the injury gives her an excuse to basically cuddle her out in the open.

"No, I've got this. Just leave the reports on the desk with the others. I'll get back to them soon," Adora replies. She swears she feels a faint rumble come off Catra, running through her own chest as well. Adora desperately wants to squeeze Catra close and bury her face in her mane, but she somehow resists the urge as Scorpia nods and straightens up. She seems to have forgotten she has files tucked under her arm and drops them when she raises her pincer to give Adora a salute. Adora stifles a snort as Scorpia hurries to pick up and stack the papers that immediately slide all over the floor.

"You got it, boss! I've got some normal field reports, a requisition request, and some stuff addressed directly to Shadow Weaver. I'll, uh, get it sorted and then leave it on the desk!" Scorpia hurries to assure her as she settles for just scooping up all the papers and giving Adora a flustered smile. Adora nods to dismiss her and sets down the hall again. She really wants to get back to her room. Catra might actually let Adora cuddle her then.

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Catra would have protested Adora babying her like this – she is sore and going to bruise, but she isn't *injured* really – if she didn't want to talk to her in private. She also kind of doesn't want to deal with Scorpia from the moment that she coos at her. She hates being treated like some cutesy kitten who can't handle herself. She finds herself kneading against Adora's shoulder just to soothe the agitation that thought causes, but Adora doesn't seem bothered. Maybe it doesn't hurt her in this form.

She would still let Catra do it regardless, but Catra always felt guilty about it when her claws would snag on Adora and cause her to wince, so she usually resorted to using her blanket despite how it eventually became ripped and threadbare. It wasn't like she slept in her own bunk all that often anyway. Catra ends up kneading against Adora for the rest of the walk back to the quarters they have been sharing. She thinks lying down would actually be bad for her given the impact to her back, but she lets Adora sit down on the edge of the bed and cuddle her for a moment.

It feels *ridiculous* to be cuddling this seven-foot warrior, and Catra doesn't quite know how she feels about being so small in comparison to Adora, but Adora sighs happily as she hugs Catra and rubs her face into her hair, mirroring the affectionate nuzzling that Catra has been sneaking in while they are alone for years. Now they get to sleep in their own room, they don't have to be quite so secretive. For a moment, Catra gives into the urge to nuzzle back, lifting her head and rubbing their cheeks together.

Adora eagerly shifts position to give her better access, hugging her close as she does so. Okay, so Catra actually likes being held as long as she isn't being treated like she can't handle being thrown around a little. She has walked off far worse in training exercises, she really doesn't know why Adora decided that she can't handle it today, but the way she has been able to hold onto She-ra long after the danger has passed just to *carry* her has given her some insight – at least she hopes – into how she works.

After she is done rubbing their faces together and marking Adora with her scent, Catra pulls back and wriggles a little until Adora sets her down in her lap instead of continuing to hold her in the air above it. Adora looks down at her with a soft expression that, after being carried through the halls, feels less at odds with the rest of She-ra. This is a different side to her than Catra has seen before, but it is a distinctly *Adora* one.

"To be clear, I'm perfectly fine and you're going back to training after we talk," Catra tells her, raising her finger and pointing forcefully at Adora. Adora, predictably, pouts at her. Oh fuck, She-ra's large blue eyes somehow increase Adora's kicked puppy factor by eleven. Catra feels herself blush, her tail lashing behind her as she tries to huff and be stern with Adora, but it's hard when she is looking at her like *that*.

"What about cuddles?" Adora asks, pouting like she isn't a glowing magic *warrior* right now. Catra's ears pin back and she practically headbutts Adora's armored chest in her rush to hide her face against her. She can feel Adora grinning down at the top of her head, but she can't help it. Words like *cuddles* have no place in the Horde and yet Adora's arms are strong around her. Part of Catra says to scan around for someone who could overhear them – for *danger* – and the rest of her says to fall gladly into Adora's arms.

"*Some*," Catra concedes. Adora's pout goes from pleading to sulking. She reaches up with one of her unusually-large hands and carefully slides it beneath Catra's mane, framing her ear with her fingers and massaging at the base. A traitorous purr begins in Catra's chest as she sinks down into the affection, the tip of her tail happily flicking. Her eyes fall shut without her meaning for them too. She isn't used to physical attention like this and it feels *good*.

It is going to take more than a few days of getting to sleep side-by-side and steal kisses in the evening to undo a lifetime of having to calculate every touch and finding excuses to have contact in activities like wrestling. Catra supposes it couldn't hurt

to let them both enjoy it for just a few more moments before they get back to work. They are both exhausted by the time they get back to their room in the evenings and could use a minute of relaxation. Being Second is hard.

Shadow Weaver made it look easy. Intimidate a few people, scar some cadets for fun, and it all falls into place. Not that other people are the problem, they fall in line now that Adora has proven herself with the Thaymor invasion, but there is a lot more work to it than either of them ever knew. Apparently Adora had *some* idea of the paperwork involved – she has sat in on one or two meetings with Shadow Weaver before and even filed things for her in those times when Shadow Weaver would take her off on her own – but the learning curve is steep.

Catra is worried about Adora not being able to keep She-ra up the further from the context of fighting she is, though, so eventually she is forced to pull back with a sigh. Adora is a little *shit* so she switches to scratching at the base of Catra's ear then, knowing that it is enough to make her melt on most days, and Catra reluctantly swats her hand away, fixing Adora with a glare that she just has to hope isn't cut too much by the flustered twitching of her ears or the blush on her cheeks.

"How'd you manage to summon She-ra?" Catra asks her. Adora pouts, dropping her hand down reluctantly, though she seems to brighten a little when she realizes this just means she can go back to wrapping Catra up in a hug. Catra lets herself be cuddled against Adora's chest only in the hopes that She-ra will stick around if Adora is using her strength and not at all because she enjoys it.

"I don't know, I saw you get hit and she was just right there at my fingertips. Nothing mattered but making sure you were okay," Adora admits, shrugging a little. Her words sound a little put out, like she is disappointed she doesn't understand more about why she was able to push through the block then, but Catra thinks that she understands *plenty*. She hums an acknowledgement, tilting her head as she takes in Adora's expression, which is turning a bit

anxious now. Catra swears her golden luminescence is dimming too.

"You need something to fight for. It's not about danger, it's about *purpose*," Catra proposes. Adora's danger theory just didn't make any sense with how she summoned She-ra out in the woods, but if it is about intent and purpose, Adora had plenty of it then, even if it was just to annoy Catra with her new big muscles. To her surprise, Adora looks away with a sigh. She doesn't seem surprised by that theory.

"I know. And that's why I can't really summon her. I know we're supposed to be bettering the Horde, I just… It's hard when I don't know if I should be serving them in the first place," Adora admits, her voice dwindling down to a whisper so quiet that Catra has to train her ears forward to make it out. Adora says it like she feels ashamed to be having these doubts. Catra would refer to it as having two eyes and a conscience, but she is pretty sure the latter is a hindrance amongst the Horde's ranks. She frowns at Adora's grief-stricken expression as Adora continues to stare down at the ground.

"Then don't fight for the Horde. Don't fight for what they are, or what they have done in the past. Fight for what they could be. Fight for the chance to make a difference. Fight for *me*. This isn't about the Horde, Adora. It's about us. We're finally here. Let's do this the way that we always wanted to. Shadow Weaver is in a cell. She doesn't get a say anymore," Catra tells her, reaching up to touch her cheek and gently direct Adora's gaze back to hers. When Adora's eyes lock with hers, they are burning.

Catra can see the conflict in them. She really can't stand what she has learned in recent days. Catra offers her an encouraging smile, stroking along her jaw both to soothe her and because she *can*. She also can't help her fascination with the differences between Adora and She-ra. She is missing the thin scar that normally decorates her jaw from when they were training together as young cadets. She-ra's skin feels the same as Adora's, but it is unblemished by scars. Still, the look of conflict in her eyes is all

Adora, as is the look of determination that slowly fades in to replace it as Adora nods.

"To make things better?" she asks. From her tone, Catra can guess that she really does need the assurance this will make something better. Thaymor – or rather, Light Hope – seriously messed with her head. Well, that isn't laying blame where it is due: *Shadow Weaver* messed with her head and Adora is only just now realizing it. Catra nods, slipping her hand down so she can hook her arm over Adora's shoulders and draw herself closer.

"To make things better. You'll be *helping*," Catra promises. Adora lets out a shaking breath and then offers Catra a smile both tremulous and wide. She is visibly thankful as she tightens her arms around Catra and draws her into an almost crushing hug. Catra is aware of She-ra's muscles around her, but Adora is clearly cognizant of her injuries and doesn't squeeze too hard.

"I just want to make a difference. A *good* one," Adora says, her voice small, but She-ra's form is still solid, so Catra feels confident they made headway. Catra offers her an encouraging smile, dropping her head on Adora's shoulder and looking up at her as she goes limp in her arms, making it clear that she isn't afraid of her no matter how big she is right now. Adora isn't some monster fighting for the bad guys. She is a person trying to do the right thing.

"You will. You're not in this alone. I'll help you every step of the way," Catra promises her. Finally, enough of the tension leaves Adora's face for her to truly smile down at Catra. They both should resume working and Adora should really go get some practice in, but for the moment Catra decides its time to reward Adora. She nuzzles against her shoulder, eventually tucking her face into Adora's neck and leaving herself open to those cuddles that Adora wanted so badly.

Adora gladly takes the opening to hug her close, sighing softly as she squeezes her. For once, her breath isn't loaded with tension.

# Plumeria

Chapter Notes

> CW: mention of "fantasy guns" (the zap blasts they had in the show) & brief worry about harm to a child.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were making some real headway on the task of arranging all of the Horde's logistics – or rather, *familiarizing* themselves with all the Horde's logistics so they could then arrange them – but She-ra ate up enough time that they weren't able to work through what remained of their work pile that night. She might have gotten to it last night if she hadn't fussed over Catra until she agreed to go to bed early, but she wanted to make sure Catra wasn't too stiff the next day.

She got injured trying to help Adora – with her sim, with unlocking She-ra, and with just not giving up – and Adora hates the idea of being the source of Catra's pain. She has been the reason for a number of the punishments that Catra received in the past – either because Shadow Weaver was trying to teach Adora a lesson or because she refused to believe some transgression was Adora's idea and not Catra's – and every time it made her heart ache.

Besides, it was nice getting to lie in bed with Catra draped across her chest last night. Adora should have a stronger work ethic, and usually she *does*, but she has always been weak for Catra. Catra seemed to both enjoy and loathe the attention in equal measure. At first she snapped at Adora that she wasn't even hurt, but once they were in their bed, she happily flopped down onto Adora and purred. The sheer amount of purring she did last night was incredible and Adora might just make it her life's mission to earn those rumbles as often as she can now.

Unfortunately, they have to fall back into their regular routine when they wake up. Catra admits that her back feels a bit sore, but she doesn't acknowledge it being any worse than that. With her movement not seeming to be affected, they unfortunately have to get back to work. Adora is planning to try to go back to the training sim tonight to see if she can summon She-ra again – though she doesn't think she will have as much trouble now that her resolve has been hardened – so she needs to get as much done beforehand as possible.

If she had seen what was in the new files Scorpia brought yesterday, she might not have gone to bed early. It is one file in particular, a report out of Plumeria addressed directly to Shadow Weaver, that has her pressing her lips together as she reads it. Her reaction is strong enough that Catra notices it and abandons her own reading to peer over Adora's shoulder with her brow furrowed. The page takes a moment to reveal its horror, but once she reads far enough, Adora watches her tail thud once, almost nervously.

Hordak has an ongoing project in Plumeria. Shadow Weaver was running it, but he is the one who built the machine currently poisoning the Heart-Blossom so that they can easily take the city. It's tactics like this that turn Adora's stomach. Whoever wrote the report has clearly bought into the logic that the princesses are dangerous and anything that curbs their power is a good thing, but the descriptions of the land and foliage dying go far beyond impacting just the princess who uses the runestone.

Adora looks at the page and all she can think of is Light Hope's warnings about how the princesses and their runestones need to be in balance for Etheria to function. The collateral damage from warfare like this could extend far beyond Plumeria. Destroying an ecosystem isn't worth taking out one dangerous individual – if Princess Perfuma even *is* that dangerous. From the way Light Hope made it sound, the princesses are entrusted with the runestones. It might be that they are the only ones who can handle their power.

Adora doesn't know. She does know that this is *wrong* – and worse yet, she knows that Hordak has had a personal hand in this. She can't just end the operation now that Shadow Weaver is indisposed. It doesn't soothe her to know that so many people high up in the Horde are involved with this operation and seemingly condone it. Something like this might help them win the war, but it isn't how one should be *fought*.

"Hey guys- whoa, everything okay?" Scorpia asks, her pincer falling from where she was beginning to wave as she walked in. She glances between Catra and Adora as they both read over the report. Adora doesn't know what to say to that. No, it is very much *not okay*. She looks up, desperately trying to make eye contact with Catra, but she is still reading to the end of the page. Adora doesn't know if she can handle whatever new horrors it may contain.

"I need to talk to Hordak. We can't keep doing this," Adora says, going to set the paper aside but being quickly stopped by Catra grabbing for it so she can keep reading it. Her ear twitching and brow raising is the only acknowledgement that she gives of Adora's words, but Scorpia looks to her with clear surprise. "They're poisoning the land in Plumeria to force the people out of the city. They're going to destroy *everything*," Adora tells Scorpia as she starts walking towards her. Scorpia doesn't look any less confused, shooting a look to Catra. Finally, Catra looks up from the page to meet Adora's eyes.

"Adora, wait – they're requesting backup. They think the city is vulnerable enough to fall now. Scouts report that Princess Perfuma's powers are useless," Catra tells her. Adora feels a sharp spike of betrayal in her heart, gaping at Catra. She can't be just *glossing over this*. Adora doesn't care if it has weakened a dangerous opponent – this isn't what she wants to sacrifice to get there. An acrid taste rises in her throat as she vehemently shakes her head.

"You can't be serious. We can't win like this," Adora returns, though her voice is less accusatory and more pleading. *Please, tell*

*me you aren't serious*. Catra can't possibly approve of these tactics. War is messy and violent, but this is going too far. Catra sighs, the sound sharp as she flips back a page and turns the file around, showing Adora the schematic that Hordak drew for the initial design of the machine now pumping chemicals into the roots of the Heart-Blossom.

"This is Hordak's machine. We can't just pull the plug on it. *But*, if we take the city, there will be no point in continuing to poison the land," Catra points out, gesturing to the schematic to illustrate her point. The corners of Adora's mouth turn down as she frowns at Catra, but Catra just raises a brow at her in response. "If you call for Hordak to stop this without a good reason, he'll probably just demote you for questioning him. She-ra could put a stop to this and pull off a major victory at the same time," Catra tacks on.

Adora fists her hands at her sides. She hates it, but it's *smart*. She wants to go demand from Hordak how a military that operates like this could be better than whatever the princesses are doing with the Rebellion, but Catra is right: that would just get her reprimanded at best and demoted at worst, taking away her ability to make any changes. They agreed to improve things from the inside, to make a difference, and that means not getting hotheaded about the first thing they find that *really* needs to change.

"Fine. But we go right away. This needs to be stopped," Adora relents. They shouldn't – they are just barely getting a handle on running things here and deploying to Plumeria is going to put them behind again – but they can't leave the people of Plumeria to suffer the poisonous effects of what the Horde is doing to their land. This is what Adora wants to use She-ra for: to stop suffering and make things *better*. The Horde will have to deal with remote management for a little while. Adora needs to make sure that the people of Plumeria don't starve.

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They leave that night. Adora only wants to wait long enough to get transport arranged. Adora arranges for Scorpia to take over in-person duties for them while Catra runs around and informs everyone of their plans to deploy to Plumeria and that they will need to report in to Adora remotely. As Adora exchanges messages with the vehicle bay and gets their transport ready, Catra has to take care of one last piece of business: Shadow Weaver.

Catra doesn't even open the door to her cell most days, just looking in to assess that she is alive, but she only has two or three days of rations left and she needs to have more if they are leaving. They will likely be at Plumeria for that long and neither of them want to *starve* her. Well, okay, sometimes Catra thinks about it vindictively, but she would never actually do it. She is bitter and angry, but she isn't cruel like Shadow Weaver. She refuses to be.

They can't have anyone else bring her food, so Catra gets an extra week of rations and heads down to the cell reluctantly. She didn't come yesterday, but she doesn't know that Shadow Weaver can always tell when she comes to peer through the door anyway, so it's possible that she just assumed she missed her. For all of Catra's talk, she feels compelled to come check on Shadow Weaver regularly. She doesn't seem well and it feels dangerous to leave her for too long.

When Catra arrives at the cell, she finds Shadow Weaver hunched over on the bed, facing the wall. Over her shoulder, Catra can see tally marks scratched in the wall. She raises a brow at Shadow Weaver's back as she deposits her delivery near the head of the bed. Shadow Weaver seems intent on ignoring her today. Catra doesn't doubt it is the first of many strategies she will try to elicit sympathy out of her, but they aren't going to work.

"You missed one," she comments as she turns and walks back to the door. She gets no response. She pauses when she reaches the door, glancing back over her shoulder to find Shadow Weaver

slowly and painstakingly lifting her hand from her lap and slowly beginning to scratch a new tally into the wall. Catra bites her lip. It really seems like the movements pain her despite how she should be… well, not *healthy*, but fine. Catra asked about her shoulder the last time that she came down and Shadow Weaver brushed her off gruffly, telling her she didn't need concern from her captor.

The arrow wound on her left should be all healed now, and even if it isn't, Shadow Weaver is right-handed. She shouldn't have trouble moving to scratch that tally. Catra feels a sense of disquiet that she quickly shoves down, turning away and continuing out the door. Yes, Hordak said that Shadow Weaver needed the Black Garnet to live, but surely she would say something if she was actually dying, right? Self-preservation is kind of Shadow Weaver's whole thing. She wouldn't let herself waste away down here. She would be trying to manipulate Catra into… whatever she thinks would help her.

She has to be fine, Catra assures herself, but her tail lashes as she makes her way out of the cell block.

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Adora is anxious when they finally reach Plumeria. Well, she has been anxious this entire time, but as they finally come in sight of the base, she realizes that these soldiers are all bought into their purpose here. She has earned herself some respect in the Horde with the invasion of Thaymor, but it likely hasn't spread to outposts like this, and she is going to have to earn the respect of the soldiers here while also pretending not to hate what they have been doing.

"They're preparing for an invasion, Adora. They'll be too busy to be scrutinizing you," Catra assures her as they approach. Adora

bites her lip, knowing her expression must be pinched. If Catra can see her worries so plainly, what chance does she have of keeping her feelings hidden from the soldiers? At least Catra is right about one thing: she won't have to do it long. The base received word to prepare for a raid after her arrival. If everything is going well, they might be able to launch the attack tonight.

"Look at the ground," Adora can't help but point out. As they have traveled, the ground turned lush and green upon leaving behind the Fright Zone, but now it is brown, withered or barren as they finally reach the base walls.

"It will regrow. Focus on the invasion. If it goes right, everything else falls into place," Catra assures her. Adora catches herself leaning onto Catra's shoulder, straining towards those words of encouragement. She hopes Catra is right. She doesn't know a lot about plants, but according to the file that Catra was able to dig up before they left, Princess Perfuma can control them. Without her powers, will they all wither away? Can this area even survive her absence?

Adora can't help but worry about what Light Hope said. She feels a looming fear inside her that this operation could prove that everything she warned Adora about is true. She needs it to be false for the sake of her sanity. She hates the idea of supporting something like this already, but if it turns out that the damage is long term, she doesn't know what she will do. Even worse, it feels like she may be the only one who *cares*.

Catra cares too, of course, but while Catra understands her disquiet, they are already in this together and they can't open up about their concerns to other people in the Horde for fear of being ostracized for *compassion*. Adora presses her lips into a thin line. Catra is right that there is one thing that she can do to end this. Her emotions will have to wait. Her priority is taking the town and then immediately shutting that machine down.

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The base is alight with a quiet buzz of activity when they finally arrive. Everybody is excited and nervous about the upcoming invasion. It works to their advantage: it seems that everybody is too busy preparing – mentally and physically – for them to question Adora's motivations. After all, they did request backup to support such an invasion. The speed with which Adora wants it done isn't that unusual for the Horde. Hordak always expects efficiency.

"We are always ready to fight in case Plumeria decides to attack, but we don't have enough men to mount an invasion on our own," the base leader explains as he takes them to the large structure in the middle of the base that apparently protects the poison-pumping machine. Catra scoffs, drawing both his and Adora's attention. This is the exact moment where a leader needs to take charge and be confident. Inspiring troops is important, but Adora is a little too hyper focused on the machine to do it herself.

"You have She-ra. She is as good as an army on her own. Prepare your men. We can't be away from the Fright Zone long and want to deploy right away," Catra tells him, sending Adora a sly, confident smirk. The look is almost conspiratorial, as if the very idea of She-ra being doubted is funny. Catra does think that She-ra could do this on her own, at least as long as Adora is willing to actually utilize her powers, but her confidence is mostly a projection to assure the base leader.

If he believes, it will trickle down to the soldiers under his command. That belief will be crucial to getting everybody prepared for the invasion in time. It seems to work. He only hesitates a few moments before nodding saluting to Adora. The flash of doubt in Adora's eyes vanishes as she straightens her shoulders back, giving him a curt nod of acknowledgement. The soldier doesn't seem to notice her momentary uncertainty, turning to the door and opening it for them.

"Of course. Here is the machine for your inspection. I need to go prepare the troops right away. Come see me if you have any questions," he returns. Adora doesn't acknowledge him, her eyes widening as she sees the machine for the first time. It is *giant*, impressive in its scale alone. It would be awe-inspiring if the poisonous liquid in the tanks didn't glimmer such an ominous green in the low light of the protective structure. They knew what the machine would look like based off the schematics and photo in the file, but the page couldn't convey how *huge* it would be.

"We'll join you soon. Put She-ra at the front of the charge. She can bust through the defenses," Catra dismisses the base leader. He salutes and turns to walk away, leaving them alone with the machine. As soon as the door closes behind him, Catra cautiously approaches Adora, who has walked forward to the machine in a trance-like state. Her head is tilted up, taking in the grand scale of the machine that appears to be plugged directly into a massive tree root.

"As soon as we take the city, we can shut it off," Catra assures, her voice quiet. Adora is quiet for a long moment before she turns to face Catra. Catra is anticipating seeing that old doubt and conflict in Adora's gaze, even half-expecting that she will need to give Adora a quiet pep talk now before they can go out and face the troops, but she is surprised to find Adora's expression grim and set with steely determination.

"Let's end this," she says, the gemstone in her sword's hilt dully glowing in the dim light of the structure.

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Seeing the machine isn't as bad as she feared it would be, but it is still *wrong*. Inside this structure, the barren ground is removed from context, but the reality is that this contraption is causing

death and decay all around them. Adora was afraid that she would feel a dangerous waver in her conviction and be unable to summon She-ra, but seeing the device only makes her *more* determined to put an end to this. They quickly rejoin the base leader to review plans.

The base is scattered as everyone scrambles to prepare for the invasion. Adora takes point, going over the intelligence that they have and laying out a battleplan for approaching the city. The layout of the city that the scouts have sketched looks suspiciously close to that of Thaymor, though the buildings here are mostly square – probably because a lot of them are *tents* according to the soldier briefing Adora. There is no defensive wall and the city doesn't seem very large.

By fanning out and presenting a united front, they might be able to intimidate the Plumerians or at least trick them into thinking they are facing a larger force than they are. As determined as Adora is to end this, she is doing it for the Plumerians sake as much as that of the planet. She doesn't want to hurt them. Better that they turn tail and run. Hopefully word of what happened at Thaymor will have spread. If there are already fearful whispers about She-ra, all the better.

Well, all the better for this battle, but the very thought makes Adora's skin itch even as she raises her sword and transforms. This time, She-ra comes easily to her. The soldiers falling in line behind her watch her with awe, so she puts on a show, pounding her fists together to form her gauntlets and brandishing her sword. When she is transformed, she turns to meet eyes with Catra, finding herself greeted with a proud nod of approval and an amused smile. They both know that Adora can transform faster, but they aren't on the approach yet and she thinks she prefers taking her time.

"For the Horde!" Adora declares as proudly as she can, leading the troops forward from the base's gates. She doesn't feel the war cry in her heart – she isn't fighting *for* the Horde today – but the soldiers cheer as they flood out from the gate and quickly begin

spreading out, shoulder-to-shoulder in two dense lines to give the impression from the front that an entire army could be marching in formation. Adora leads them from the front, their destination clear thanks to the Heart-Blossom towering over the trees.

Thaymor was a sneak attack. They don't have the men to do that now. No, they want the city to see them coming and cower in fear. They have weaponry with them and the sound of it rolling out behind them would give away their position if She-ra's glow didn't cast further than the sound. Adora marches ahead of the rest. She said it was so that she could use She-ra's powers without worrying about the soldiers becoming collateral, but really she just wants to make sure she is the first to meet the city's defenses so she can minimize harm to civilians. She saw the way that the Horde flattened everything in its path back in Thaymor.

As they approach the city, Adora finally catches a glimpse of the tents and small huts that form it. It is less developed than Thaymor, spread out amongst the trees. Adora watches people begin to emerge from the structures, drawn out by the light and noise. For several long seconds, the people either hold still, apparently transfixed, or raise their hands to their eyes and squint at them. She-ra might be golden, but her ambient light is far from blinding, so Adora doesn't know why they are taking the time to try to make out details when an army is approaching.

To her shock, it is the small form of a fawn child that breaks the spell. They run forward, as if to charge and take the army on by themselves. A pang of panic drives right through Adora's throat like a spike. It can only be the pure stupidity of childhood that would bid a child, sure they can take on the world, to run towards an army. Fear and adrenaline flood through Adora as she imagines one of the soldiers behind her raising a weapon and firing at the child. She can't let it happen.

More people rush forward, calling as they do, but Adora can't make out the words in the din of noise suddenly rising from the village over the blood pounding in her ears. She doesn't know if the townspeople are running to grab the child or if they truly

believe that they can hold off an army empty-handed, but she can't let them get close. She needs to turn them back. Adora raises her sword, flipping it so the tip points down to the ground and then using both her hands to slam it down into the ground.

She still doesn't understand her magic, but she channels the anxiety and adrenaline she feels into the action, driving the sword down into the ground and causing fissures to radiate out from it. Moves like this are why she had the army hang back. She can't control the localized earthquake's direction – or at least, she doesn't know how to. She looks up from the fissures, watching the civilians scramble back, turning to try to outrun the shaking earth even as the tents at the edge of town topple.

As soon as the earth settles around her, the Horde soldiers press forward, advancing on the town. They spread out and flank Adora on either side, their numbers appearing to multiply as they spread out and raise their weapons. Some of her anxious energy dispelled in the attack, Adora's hearing clears enough for her to realize that the sounds coming from the civilians were joyous at the same moment that they shift to screams of terror.

A cold trickle of horror runs down her spine with the realization. She watches the child that first ran forward turn away with the others, their cries audible even across the chasm of disturbed earth between Adora and the town. No one is trying to run towards them now. She watches people flood from the huts, carrying objects or trying to tear their tents up from the ground as they flee like scurrying rats.

Afraid the soldiers might still try to fire on them, Adora throws her fist up, signaling to hold fire as the people scramble away. Her heart is pounding, her feet feeling rooted to ground, but she manages to pick them up and continue the advance. It keeps up the pressure to flee without having to hurt the civilians. There is no need to do more when the people are already fleeing.

She was expecting Princess Perfuma to make an appearance just like Princess Glimmer did back in Thaymor, but if she is amongst

the fleeing civilians, she doesn't stand out. She doesn't try to stand and fight – no one does. By the time that Adora reaches the edge of the town, it is almost entirely abandoned, the stragglers fleeing into the trees. Adora motions for the Horde to charge and they do so eagerly, rushing amongst the buildings to secure their victory without even having to use charge on firing a weapon.

As Adora watches the last few people disappear into the Whispering Woods, casting fearful glances back over their shoulders, she feels She-ra flicker, her warmth replaced by a cold, heavy feeling. She tries to hold onto her, but a feeling not dissimilar to dread has flooded through her, and it is hard to hold onto She-ra's light when she can hear a distant, fearful cry of, "The Horde has *She-ra!*"

Standing in the middle of the abandoned town, She-ra flickers and vanishes in the blink of an eye. It isn't the height difference leaving Adora feeling small. The troops around her cheer for their victory, but she feels none of the triumph that accompanied her back at Thaymor. She is hollow, the only emotion she can feel one of building dread.

Chapter End Notes

> I would like to thank Clare and her hyper specific insanity for the reference shots that helped me write this fic, particularly these two.

# No Flowers For She-ra

Chapter Notes

> Happy late Adora day lol. I wrote 12k yesterday but it was for a different AU

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra expected at least *someone* to try to fight, but as they work their way into the city, it becomes clear that none of the buildings contain any weapons, nor did the people fleeing seem to have them. In fact, some possessions already seem to have been packed up before their arrival but were still left behind in the rush. The plants around the town are wilted and Adora frowns every time she catches sight of one, a dark look flashing in her eye. She isn't happy about this despite the invasion going as smoothly as it possibly could have.

Catra was worried about what would happen if Adora had to fight a civilian. She doesn't think that she could have done it. Having her at the forefront was good for the intimidation strategy, but it meant all eyes would have been on her if she pulled back and refused to fight. Luckily, they didn't have to cross that bridge. Neither the civilians nor their princess rose up to challenge the advance. The Horde took the town easily. As the troops are distracted with exploring the town, Adora's eyes wander up to the Heart-Blossom looming over them.

Its leaves are wilted and rotting. The only thing around it that seems to be thriving are small clusters of mushrooms around its base. Adora turns away from the town, making her way up the small hill that the tree sits atop of. Catra follows behind her. The tree is impressive even in its wilted state. It is clearly important to the people of Plumeria. In addition to the runestone it has seemingly grown around, there are embroidered tapestries hanging from its lower branches and shallow carvings in its bark, decorated with paint.

Adora approaches it slowly, almost seeming awestruck. Catra would be more worried about the runestone lashing out at her like the lightning that occasionally arcs off of the Black Garnet, but then again she has only ever seen that happen around Shadow Weaver. Adora seems a bit mesmerized – or at least unafraid – as she approaches the tree, walking right up to the runestone and staring into it, like its dull shine will reveal secrets to her.

"I prefer the Black Garnet," Catra comments, coming up to stand beside Adora and crossing her arms as she considers the tree. If Adora is going to be close, Catra isn't going to leave her standing out on her own. Adora snorts a little, tilting her head as she continues to contemplate the round stone in the tree's center.

"I like it. It's rosy. You blush this color sometimes," she comments. Catra's tail twitches. Well, she certainly wouldn't know. She doesn't know if Adora is trying to inform her of its color in case it somehow comes up or if she genuinely just likes the color, but she seems to have moved on already, her head turning so her eyes can track along the artwork scrawled across the tree's bark and the drapery hanging from its branches. It is kind of hard for Catra to make out – some of the colors are definitely muddling together in her limited vision – but the decorations seem to be depictions of the princesses of Etheria.

Catra isn't too interested in princess propaganda, but Adora seems transfixed. After a moment, she walks forward to inspect some of the drapery. As she approaches it, Catra realizes what she is looking at. The decorations tell the stories of the princesses, so She-ra is included. Fighting some kind of monster, maybe a dragon, or seeming to bestow something on a crowd of people, or just standing over a flourishing landscape.

The depictions are abstract and kind of hard to make sense of without any words. They clearly show a hero, though. Catra nervously watches Adora's expression out of the corner of her eye. She expects her to at least seem crestfallen by the juxtaposition between what the Plumerians have depicted her as and what she has done, but instead Adora seems too busy

roaming her eyes over the images to be affected by the imagery. Catra doesn't know what she expects to get from them.

"I think She-ra is healing these people. Look," Adora says, reaching out to point at the depiction of She-ra seeming to sweep a beam across a crowd of onlookers reaching up towards her. For a moment, Catra doesn't know where she got that from, but when she steps closer and inspects it she notices that the people on one side of the beam are no longer reaching up, appearing joyful and peaceful, while the other half of the image depicts figures that are doubled over, leaning on each other, or reaching up desperately towards the beam of magic making its way to them. Some of them have clear injuries.

Catra doesn't know shit about art. Cadets sometimes sketch stuff in the Horde and Catra was no exception, but aside from throwing a paper airplane at Adora that had crude sketches of the two of them on it, she doesn't know if there is some kind of convention that explains what this image is actually depicting. Without that knowledge, Adora's interpretation does make sense to her. Given that She-ra has seem to come with a lot of inherent knowledge, Adora's belief it is possible is as good of an indicator that it is true as the drawing itself is.

"That's probably the stuff you have to train for, right?" Catra asks, stepping back to stand by Adora's shoulder again. Fighting certainly seems to have come naturally to her, but both Light Hope and Shadow Weaver implied there was more for Adora to learn. Adora bites her lip, shrugging as she casts her eyes up into the Heart-Blossoms canopy. Above them, the moons have risen, one peeking through the branches and another off to the side.

"Do you think I could heal it?" Adora asks, her voice a quiet whisper. It takes Catra a moment to realize that she is looking up at the wilted and barren branches. Her tail twitches as her eyes travel down from the branches to the tapestry. Healing people is a far cry from rejuvenating plants. Maybe the fact that the plant is dying of poison and not… whatever factors make a plant die naturally makes the skill transferrable, but she kind of doubts it.

“I don’t know. The machine will come down quickly though,” she points out. If the Horde wants to hold the town – and more importantly, the Heart-Blossom – they need to guard it, which means transferring everything from their old base into town and setting up shop here. Well, everything except the machine, which will be sent back to the Fright Zone. It will have to be taken down right away so it isn’t unguarded, though. Adora doesn’t seem assured by that knowledge, turning to look at the runestone in the trunk. Her shoulders are tense.

“It’s dying,” she whispers. Catra flinches a little, her ears twitching back. She lifts a hand, placing it on Adora’s shoulder and squeezing to assure her. Catra can’t deny that the tree looks like a husk of something formerly glorious, but it will bounce back without the machine in place, right? It has clearly lasted a long time.

“Force Captain Adora?” someone calls from down the hill. Adora startles, forced to turn away from the tree as she looks to see who is addressing her. Upon spotting them, she gives a small sigh and starts forward to see what they need. Catra trails behind her, not sure what to say and unable to give it voice now that they are in earshot of others anyway.

As they return to inspecting the town and begin the process of cataloging what they have found, a haunted look remains in Adora’s eye.

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By sunrise, everyone is exhausted, but the entire force was part of the invasion – they needed the numbers – and so some people have to stay up to guard their new territory. Adora immediately volunteers to be one. She calls it leading by example, but Catra has a knowing look in her eye. Soldiers tuck into the tents and

bungalows already set up and the town appears to empty out very quickly.

She and Catra will have to be quiet, but the few guards remaining are focused on looking outwards and it gives them relative privacy for the first time since leaving the back of their transport. Catra doesn't seem at all surprised when the first thing that Adora does is duck into a building and hold the sword aloft, but she does quickly raise her hands and motion for her to stop. Adora isn't going to be deterred.

"I'm doing this, Catra. I have to try," she tells her, her voice set with determination despite how she keeps it low. She has a feeling that she is *capable* of this, but she has no idea what she is doing. Catra rolls her eyes, walking over to the window and pointedly closing the curtains.

"I know you are. You can't be talked down from anything. Let's not make a scene, though," Catra returns before crossing to the door, peeking out and then shutting it as well. She turns back to Adora and makes a shooing motion with her hand, a clear *go ahead*. Adora can admit that shutting the window was probably a good idea. Even though she is the epicenter of the light that beams out from her transformation and unaffected by it, she can tell that it is bright. It would draw attention. The other soldiers might even think it is an attack.

Adora has had a gnawing feeling that she thinks might be guilt – she hates it, whatever it is – in her stomach ever since arriving. It has only gotten worse with every turn of events, but when she holds the sword aloft and whispers *for the honor of Grayskull*, She-ra still comes to her easily. She *needs* her right now. She needs to heal the tree. She knows that she – probably – can't actually feel pain coming from it, but that hasn't stopped the heartache that grows worse every time she passes near it.

When the transformation is done, she barely fits in the small bungalow. The wings of her tiara scrape the ceiling and she can't brandish her sword like she normally does. Catra snickers a little,

eyeing Adora as she ducks her head so she can reach the door and make her way through it. Seeing Catra's tail twitching with amusement is a small bit of happiness, at least. Adora is relieved to see that her transformation hasn't drawn any attention when they emerge, letting them head straight up to the wilting tree.

Adora doesn't know if it is her imagination, or the loss of its people, or if maybe the tree is just reaching its breaking point, but it seems to be even worse than it was earlier. Actually, it is probably just the dawn light throwing stark light on the decayed state of the tree. Even the runestone seems dimmer. They walk over fallen leaves as they approach, most of them limp and lifeless, though a few of them are desiccated and crumbling.

Adora stops just a few feet back from the runestone, looking up to her right so she can model her pose off the one depicted in the tapestry. Catra takes a few steps back in her periphery as Adora raises her sword and points its tip at the runestone. She takes a deep breath, steadying herself before she closes her eyes and tries to focus on an image depicted in a different tapestry: the Heart-Blossom full and thriving, its branches bursting with life as a woman tends to its roots. That is what it is supposed to look like.

She has no idea what she is doing. She tries to focus on the feeling of warmth that buzzes in her chest when she is She-ra, imagining pushing that out through the sword and into the Heart-Blossom, causing its leaves to burst with life again. Slowly, the feeling in her chest builds until she notices a light pressing against her eyelids. Cautiously, she peeks an eye open. The runestone of her sword is shining dully, but nothing is happening. She takes a deep breath and closes her eyes, trying to build the warmth in her chest higher.

She feels like she keeps doing that for the next *hour*.

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Adora is unsuccessful in her attempts to heal the tree. Aside from the sword occasionally glowing, nothing happens. They don't even get to find out if that healing beam would work on the tree because she never manages to summon it. Catra can't say that she is surprised – they don't even know if She-ra *can* heal, or how she would go about doing it – but she hates the frustration and disappointment that builds in Adora over the dozen attempts that she makes before she drops her arms and flings the sword aside in frustration.

The sword lands with its point sticking down in the earth several feet away, in much the same position that they initially found it in. Adora turns away, She-ra melting away in an instant as she kicks at the ground in frustration, scuffing up a clod of dirt. Catra's ears twitch as Adora mutters *useless* to herself in a low voice. She cautiously approaches her, putting a hand on Adora's shoulder and squeezing when it isn't immediately shrugged off.

"The tree will be fine once we shut the machine off," Catra tries to assure her.

It turns out to be a lie. When the first wave of soldiers wakes, the machine is one of the first things disassembled, ostensibly so Catra and Adora can take the poison vats from it back to the Fright Zone on their transport. They can't let the formula falling into the hands of the Rebellion, but Catra is just coming up with excuses to get the machine shut down quickly.

Catra wants to make Adora feel better, but when they return to Plumeria after watching the machine get turned off and the first vat loaded for transfer, things aren't looking much better. The tree does actually seem to have improved – at least, the leaves are no longer falling off of it and Catra swears it has *perked up*, if that is possible – but it wasn't the miraculous recovery that they were both unrealistically hoping for and that Adora *needs*.

They go to bed not long after that, both of them exhausted and sleep long overdue. They are just tucked into one of the bungalows, forced to sleep apart due to the only bedding being two hammocks that absolutely can't fit two people. Catra is hopeful that sleep will help Adora refresh and actually feel a bit of the accomplishment and joy that she felt back in Thaymor, but she isn't all that surprised with she wakes at sunset and finds Adora's hammock empty.

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Adora barely manages to get on with the day of overseeing details. Realistically, she and Catra should head back to the Fright Zone now and report their victory, but she can't leave things as they are. Her heart aches every time she remembers they are in the middle of a town where children should be playing *Princess and Force Captain*, although presumably with the roles reversed. The more times she recalls the shrieks of terror from the retreating civilians, the sicker she feels.

The last straw is trying to sleep in a hammock that held a normal civilian just hours ago. Adora does *try* to sleep, and she thinks she actually gets close thanks to her exhaustion, but she just can't do it with the fluttering anxiety that is beating against her chest as if it is trying to rattle her ribcage. Quietly, she slips from the hammock and gathers her sword. There is another soldier assigned to guard the Heart-Blossom right now – two, actually – so she instead turns to the woods.

They haven't seen any sign of people attempting to return to the village – they never did at Thaymor either – and she needs to be alone. Well, alone with the *sword*. She just knows that she can heal. It never occurred to her before she saw the tapestry, but she swears she felt the stirrings of it in her chest when she was standing before the tree, she just couldn't make it *work*.

When she couldn't do something during her cadet training, she would practice it relentlessly until she was able to achieve it – at least barring frustration-induced breaks to pull at her hair, hit something, or maybe cry in a corner with Catra patting her back. That is just how you learn. No one is going to walk in on her in the woods. She can practice until she can at least summon the beam and then she can make her way back to the town to actually try using it on the tree. She has a feeling that as long as the tree is healed, the rest of the plants will recover too.

It is almost a relief to walk into the Whispering Woods again. She felt uneasy the first time that she was in them – they were unfamiliar and all the cadets were raised hearing tales of the things that can happen in them – but it is better than being in the town where everywhere she turns there are reminders of the stricken faces of the civilians that for a moment were running to embrace her before they turned and fled. Their reactions were explained by the decorations around the Heart-Blossom – they looked at She-ra as *savior*.

Instead, she drove them from their homes. Adora feels sick thinking about it. She needs to at least heal the land. Maybe one day some kind of peace can be reached. Saving the land doesn't do anything if she forces suffering on the people anyway, but – best not to think about that. Healing the Heart-Blossom has to be her priority. She wanders through the woods, trying to walk in a straight line so it will be easy to get back while also keeping an eye out for a wilting bush that she can practice on. Most of the trees look pretty sorry for themselves, but she thinks it is best if she starts smaller.

She also doesn't want to be within earshot of Plumeria. Being found practicing her powers would be embarrassing at best and discredit her at worst. Maybe they would even begin to suspect that she isn't fully invested in the Horde's mission. She stays alert as she walks, worried about stumbling across rebel fighters coming in as reinforcements to retake the city. It all seems to have been a little too easy and Adora might have suspected it was

a trap if she didn't see the genuine terror on the fleeing civilians' faces for herself.

She stiffens when the wind blows and it sounds like whispering. It is just the breeze rustling the limp leaves in the trees, but it sets her on edge. She pauses beside a tree trunk, leaning against it and pulling the sword from its sheath. She feels better with a weapon in her hand and the tree protecting her blind spot where Catra usually stands. She scans the forest around her, but after several seconds the wind dies down and the whispering sound vanishes. She sets her jaw and forges on ahead, mentally chiding herself. She *knew* it was just the wind.

The invasion has her anxious, though. Anxious doesn't even begin to capture how she feels, truly. Sometimes when she thinks about the civilians that they displaced emotions rise in her that almost taste like gasoline in her throat. None of this feels right. The plants here look wilted rather than dying now, but what good was saving the land if the people are gone from it? All she can feel is regret. She-ra isn't meant to be used to drive people from their homes. These people thought of her as a hero and instead of coming to save them, she *hurt* them.

She comes to a halt, staring down at the sword in her hand. It doesn't offer her any answers, remaining lifeless and dull in her hand. She is far enough now. She should try to transform into She-ra and see if she can heal one of these plants, but she is afraid to even try. She is afraid that she can't do it, and with her chest in turmoil like this, she is afraid that she won't even be able to summon She-ra again. She can't take another failure after failing an entire kingdom. She just doesn't know what to do.

Catra's plan to work up in the Horde made sense back in the Fright Zone, when Adora didn't have to see firsthand what terrified civilians look like, but now she doesn't know how she can go through with it for another day. Where does that leave her, though? She can't just walk away. She is She-ra. She is supposed to help Etheria, and yet she can't even figure out how to do that.

Her grand destiny hasn't magically revealed the right thing to do to her. She feels lost and hopeless-

Voices. Only this time, the wind isn't blowing. Adora quickly ducks against the nearest tree, clutching the sword in her hand as she strains her ears to listen. It sounds like a man and a woman, talking freely and not even attempting to whisper, but Adora can't make out what they're saying. It is bad news no matter who they are. They have to be either civilians or rebels, and if either are this close to Plumeria, then it could mean that they are going to try to approach the conquered city. If they do, there will be a fight. Someone is going to end up hurt.

Adora, against her better judgement, approaches the voices. She needs to know what is going on. She crouches down, trying to stay out of sight behind the undergrowth and bushes in the area, and strains her hearing as she approaches, trying to listen from as far away as she possibly can. Eventually, she starts to catch snatches of conversation and realizes they are talking about where to go. It seems like the speakers are moving, so Adora is forced to constantly edge further until she can truly make out the conversation.

"We have to go to Bright Moon. Mystacor may be closer, but it won't be able to house all of us even temporarily. It will be faster to go directly to Bright Moon than detour there for supplies. We have to trust that the land will provide for us," the higher voice says, the tone falsely light despite the obvious stress in it.

"Bright Moon hasn't answered our request for aid and hoping for things to work out just went, like, horribly wrong for us," the male voice points out, though he sounds oddly uninvested in his rebuttal. There is a long moment of silence, and when the voices start again they are a little more distant, forcing Adora to edge forward again.

"We aren't fighters. Please, Seneschal, I'm trying to do what's best for my people, and that isn't throwing them into a war to never return like our parents did. Return to camp and see to

everyone's needs. We'll leave in the morning, before the Horde can find us again," the woman says. Adora draws in a sharp breath as she realizes what she is listening to. Whoever this woman is, she is clearly a leader in Plumeria, which makes her likely Princess Perfuma herself.

That goes against everything that Adora has ever been taught about princesses. The idea of a princess who *doesn't fight* is entirely foreign to her. She feels sick to her stomach as she barely picks up on the tones of a quiet reply and then the forest goes silent. She should turn away and sneak back to Plumeria before she is caught, but she feels petrified in the bush. For what feels like an eternity, she remains crouched behind a leafy frond.

Then she hears crying. The woman didn't say why she wanted to be alone, but as quiet sobs filter through the air, it becomes clear. Adora almost begins to cry with her. She doesn't really think about it as she slowly stands from her hiding place, but she quickly spots a head of blond hair in the distance. Adora at least has the presence of mind to walk lightly as she approaches, remaining silent and following the growth of the plants so she can quickly duck out of sight if she needs to.

The woman is knelt at the base of a tree, her face in her hands as she cries quietly, having a breakdown not dissimilar to the one that Adora wants to go through. She has pink flowers in her hair and a flowing dress. Adora has very little proof, but she is certain this must be Princess Perfuma. She swallows, standing behind a woman who is supposed to be her enemy and who is unaware of her presence, but no part of her is capable of taking advantage of this opportunity. All she wants to do is comfort her.

Quietly, Adora sheathes her sword. Then she reaches up to her chest and unfastens her badge, sliding it beneath her jacket and refastening it on the inside, pressed against her shirt and out of sight. She steps to the side to duck behind a tree in order to undo her belt, fastened with her Horde Cadet badge. She carefully coils it on the ground there while Perfuma's cries cover the noise. Adora can hear them tapering off – she has to act fast. Her overt

Horde symbols are gone now, but she knows she still doesn't really look like a civilian.

She can't do much else about her clothes. This will have to be good enough. She steels her nerves for several long moments, listening to the sobs give way to hiccups and sniffles. She has to act now if she is going to. She can't believe she is even considering this, but if this *is* Princess Perfuma, then she just might be able to help Adora. Scorpia gave her a quick brief on her knowledge of Plumeria before they left on this trip.

It was the kind of stuff that Adora should have learned at Force Captain Orientation, but unfortunately, she can't exactly *go* now that she is Second. It wouldn't inspire confidence if the person leading them made it obvious that they don't even have rookie knowledge. According to Scorpia, Plumeria is ruled by Princess Perfuma and she has power over plants. In places like the Whispering Woods, she could be devastating in battle, but she is rarely seen and Plumeria in general has seemed to do its best to stay out of the war, unlike some places like Bright Moon which are always at its forefront.

Adora knows that healing isn't the exact same thing as growing, but they at least seem related. She needs to do *something* to make up for what she has done, and Perfuma is probably the best shot she has at learning to heal right now. The crying is down to slight sniffles. Adora stays paralyzed behind the tree, wondering if she really wants to walk up to someone with every reason to hate her. She doesn't get long enough to think. In the nearby clearing, she hears a loud sigh and then the sound of Perfuma standing.

Adora panics. Her best chance at doing something actually *good* is walking away. She hurries around the tree, drawing to a halt at the sight of Perfuma's back retreating slowly. Adora still has doubts, but they don't compare to her panic, and she runs forward to catch her. No longer trying to approach stealthily – or benefitting from Perfuma's cries covering any sounds that she makes – Perfuma hears her and startles, turning around when Adora is only a few yards away.

They both draw to a halt, starting at each other. After a second, Perfuma lifts her hands. The sudden movement makes Adora flinch, but no attack launches at Perfuma's command. Instead, Perfuma reaches up to her face and hurries to wipe her tears away. When her hands fall, she has a wide but completely unconvincing smile plastered across her face.

"I'm sorry, you caught me at a bad moment," Perfuma says, continuing to surprise Adora. Perfuma's eyes are still watery as she does the worst job at projecting being together that Adora has ever seen. She clearly hasn't recognized Adora yet – not that anyone saw who she was underneath She-ra in the battle, but she expected to stick out as a Horde solider like a sore thumb. Then again, Perfuma seems a bit distracted pretending that she wasn't just having a breakdown.

"Um, you're Princess Perfuma, right? You grow things and make them live?" Adora asks, awkwardly. She has no idea how to talk to a princess, much less how to pretend that she is one of their citizens. Would everyone recognize their princess on sight? How long does she have in this conversation before she trips over something obvious and the princess attacks upon realizing who she is?

"Usually. I don't have the power right now with my runestone blighted. I'm sorry, whatever you need, I can't help you," Perfuma replies, bowing her head and looking away. She looks on the verge of tears again, wilted in the middle of the forest. The trees look healthy in comparison to her. Adora's stomach turns. She takes a step forward before she can think better of it, shaking her head. She wants to assure Perfuma.

"I think you still can. I need you to teach me how to heal," Adora explains. Perfuma frowns, lifting her head and sending Adora a look that is equal parts confused and incredulous. For first time, she seems to be scrutinizing Adora. After a long moment, her eyes land on the hilt poking over Adora's shoulder and widen.

"You're-" she starts, her voice high and strangled. Adora quickly raises her hands, waving them wildly trying to cut her off before she draws the attention of the others which must be camped somewhere nearby.

"I want to help! Please, give me a chance. This- This is *wrong*. The tapestries showed She-ra healing and helping your people. I want to do that," Adora rushes out. She didn't think any of this through, much less what she was going to say. As Adora steps forward to quiet Perfuma, the princess takes a fearful step back, shaking her head.

"You're working with the *Horde*!" she returns, but it is in a panicked whisper. She is almost going along with it. Despite obviously being anxious, Adora can see a light in her eyes. It could just be anxiety, maybe even anger, but it also could be *hope*. Adora knows that if a princess showed up to the Horde claiming to want to make things right, they would lock her up in an instant, but clearly Perfuma is willing to at least give her half a chance to speak.

"Yes, but I don't want to! I mean, I- I don't know. They aren't all bad, but this definitely is. The Horde already has your city and your runestone. What else do you have to lose? Maybe if I heal it, some of your powers will come back. I just want to fix things. Please, help me do something *good*," Adora begs. She knows it probably isn't the most convincing speech, but it is honest. She isn't trying to defect, and yet – she kind of feels like she should. Everything has been confusing ever since she found the sword.

"Why would you want to help us? All the Horde does is destroy land and drive people from their homes. That's who you're working for. She-ra is supposed to be Etheria's *savior*. What kind of imposter are you?" Perfuma asks, her voice distraught. Her tones might still be low, but she clearly doesn't believe Adora. The words drive an icy spike through her heart, making her flinch back. She feels a hand raise to her chest, fisting the fabric of her jacket over where her badge is pinned out of sight.

She wants to refute that, but everything she has seen only confirms Perfuma's words. Part of Adora even wonders if the Fright Zone was a wasteland before the Horde got there or if they poisoned it too trying to drive out its native inhabitants. What really hurts her is the She-ra part. Perfuma believes that she can't be the real She-ra, because the real She-ra wouldn't do this. Adora swallows, lifting her hand up to take the hilt of the sword in her hand. Perfuma practically scrambles back from her, her eyes widening.

"For the honor of Grayskull," Adora says, her words quiet and sober. She-ra washes over her in response. She throws her head back as her hair grows out, but aside from that she is trying to be fast, transforming before Perfuma can run. Luckily, she seems transfixed by the light show happening in front of her. When Adora looks down again, now significantly taller than Perfuma, she finds the other princess looking up at her with wide eyes, her eyes roaming over her as if trying to match the details of her form to those on the tapestries.

Adora isn't an imposter, she just has done the wrong thing. As she looks at the medley of emotions on Perfuma's face, too conflicted to make out one emotion above the others, all she cares about is making it *right*. She is certain now that Perfuma is right – that *Light Hope* was. She-ra isn't meant to be used for this. Looking at the tapestries, she isn't even sure She-ra is meant just for battle. Regardless of how she is meant to go about doing it, she is supposed to serve the people of Etheria, and so far all Adora has done is terrorize them.

"I'm She-ra. I was raised as soldier in the Horde, but I don't want to hurt people. They say the princesses are tyrants and we're freeing people, but… it doesn't feel right to me. Let me heal your land, and maybe you'll be able to come back soon. At least you'll be able to use your powers to help your people again," Adora argues. She knows that she shouldn't encourage Perfuma to try to come back, but she also knows that taking Plumeria in the first place was a mistake. Rebellious thoughts are forming in the back of her mind.

Right now her priority is doing *something* to help fix the mess she has made. Perfuma finally looks up to meet her eyes, biting her lip as she looks at her. She clearly isn't sure, but Adora can't give her the assurance of promising her that she will never fight for the Horde again. She doesn't know that. In fact, the thoughts in her head say quite the opposite in a rather devious way. Maybe Catra is rubbing off on her. Maybe this is a natural extension of Catra's plan. The only thing that Adora knows for sure is that there needs to be a change.

"The Horde aren't freeing anybody. They kill anyone who refuses to run from them. They're *evil*," Perfuma returns, but she doesn't sound as hateful as her words are. It almost sounds like she is making her stance known before she goes along with this – or maybe that's just wishful thinking on Adora's part. She swallows, but she doesn't even bother shaking her head. Perfuma has earned those words after being driven from her home.

"Trust that She-ra isn't. I'm making up my plan as I go, but I want to end the war. Peacefully. I promise," Adora tells her. She just has to hope that she didn't destroy every bit of belief these people had in She-ra with her actions last night. Perfuma bites her lip, but after a long moment, she nods.

Chapter End Notes

> I think the land miraculously healing when they fought the Horde and took down the machine had as much to do with Perfuma as it did with the machine being stopped, so for this AU I had the tree remain blighted even with the machine unplugged. It would have slowly recovered on its own (and instantly recovered with Perfuma's help, but she fled with her people), but the recovery wouldn't be the burst of blooming seen in the show.

# The Heart-Blossom

Chapter Notes

> I'm planning to have (roughly) three more full fics in this series. Roughly. Who knows if they will double or combine.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra isn't surprised when she wakes up alone. She is still tired and could use several more hours of sleep, but she hauls herself out of bed and sets to prowling about the town as if she is on patrol. She tries to search subtly, but she can find no sign of Adora. Tail lashing uncertainly now, Catra quietly slips away from town and back to the old Horde base.

A path is already being established to carry the supplies – and especially the pre-fabricated defensive walls – over to Plumeria. Catra thought maybe Adora came back just to get peace of mind by checking on the progress disassembling Hordak's machine, but no one seems to be overseeing the project. More of the machine has come down and been stuffed in the back of their transport, leaving them with a cramped space for their trip back, but if it will ease Adora's mind to have it with them, Catra is willing to put up with it.

If only she could *find* Adora. She returns to Plumeria, prowling between the buildings with a growing feeling of dread. Every sign points to Adora *not being here*, and given that no one else seems alarmed, it's likely that she walked away of her own accord, likely purposefully sneaking off. Catra approaches one of the patrolling soldiers and asks if he has seen anything suspicious, narrowing her eyes when he reports that everything has been quiet.

"I'm going to patrol the edge of the woods in case any rebel backup has arrived," she tells him, mostly because she doesn't want him to question her wandering off. He nods and salutes her as she walks away. She is pretty sure that they are the same rank

– Adora has now made her an active duty soldier, a better rank than cadet without giving her any real authority – but she has been conferred some respect just by association with the Second.

Normally she would be relishing in it, but right now she is caught up worrying about Adora. She makes her way to the tree line, trying to search for a trail to follow, but the fleeing civilians left footprints and broken branches in their wake. Catra's nose is better than an average human's, but not good enough to track traces from someone who merely passed through an area, especially if it was awhile ago. Adora's scent is one that Catra intimately familiar with, but she can't pick it out in the forest breeze.

All that tells her is that Adora isn't here right now. Catra has to resort to scanning the ground, looking for a Horde bootprint. The grass doesn't allow for much in the way of footprints though and the few patches of exposed dirt she finds are either barren or only have the outlines of bare feet in them. Catra doesn't want to raise an alarm when its very possible that Adora just walked away to process her conflicted emotions in private, perhaps even to avoid someone overhearing her crying.

On the other hand, Catra doesn't know if she was upset enough to do that. She was struggling after the civilians ran in terror from her, but it usually takes a lot before Adora will plan a crying session. More often she shoves her emotions down until they come bursting out of her in the form of tears. There is no way she was secretly taken by rebels without anyone noticing something, but for all Catra knows she could have walked into the woods following another magic feeling and gotten ambushed.

Adora's disappearance could be mundane, or it could be very, very bad. Worry gnaws at Catra's stomach as she paces the perimeter again, just out of sight of the guards stationed around Plumeria. She doesn't want anyone to realize anything is wrong yet. Even if Adora *has* been ambushed, She-ra should be able to hold her own. At least, she should as long as Adora is willing to use her and wants to fight her abductors.

Catra stops dead in her tracks, forcing herself to take a deep breath before that insidious thought buries its poisonous fangs too deep. Adora was upset about the Plumerian invasion, and truthfully has *been* upset ever since meeting Light Hope, but Catra has been upset with the Horde her entire life and she still would never consider running off the join the Rebellion. Still, Adora makes questionable decisions when she runs off at night.

Catra reaches the edge of the wood and turns on her heel to retrace the route. Wandering off into the woods alone without any leads isn't going to help, but she can't just go back to be either. Instead, she paces, her sense of unease only growing.

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Adora is hoping to sneak back to Plumeria unnoticed. Partially because she hasn't come up with a lie for what she was doing and partially because she doesn't want Catra to have been worried by her disappearance. She is fighting a growing worry that she has picked the wrong direction to walk back in and gotten herself permanently lost in the woods when she hears a slight rustling and is almost immediately bowled over by a hundred and twenty pounds of cat. Adora would cry out from surprise if she wasn't totally winded as Catra pins her shoulders to the ground with her hands and sits on her hips.

"Where the hell have you been? I'm tired of waking up *alone*, Adora. I didn't know where you were or if you'd managed to get yourself captured," Catra demands – interrogates, really – her gaze darting all over her as if scanning for injuries and even sniffing the air suspiciously. She wrinkles her nose, her ears twitching back and eyes narrowing as she finally meets Adora's wide and bewildered gaze, still doing her best to catch up.

“Why do you smell like *flowers*?” Catra asks with a distinct air of disgust. Adora opens her mouth, then closes it. Forgive her for being slow when she just got tackled. She has been through a lot today and she isn’t feeling on top of her game, but she didn’t even know that she was close to the city yet. Not knowing if there are others to overhear, however, she doesn’t want to tell Catra the real answer.

“I’m kind of lost,” she admits, squinting up at Catra above her. Catra’s tail flicks, her eyes narrowing even further. She clearly isn’t buying that as an excuse for where Adora has been all this time, but Adora nervously glances to the side, scanning the bushes for anyone else who could overhear, and then looks back to Catra, hoping she gets the hint. After several long seconds of scrutinizing her, Catra seems to. She scoffs, her tail still lashing behind her.

“We’re only a minute or two from Plumeria. I’ve been looking for you for *ages*. I was just about to organize a search party,” Catra tells her, her tone bordering on accusatory. She is clearly upset. If Adora wasn’t already consumed with guilt for the invasion, it would make her feel bad, but at this point Catra’s worry is just a drop in the bucket along with everything else. Adora does her best to offer Catra a gentle smile, cautiously reaching up and placing her hands on both of Catra’s hips. She doesn’t need any help balancing as she pins Adora to the ground, but she thinks touch in general will help assure her.

“I wanted to try to heal without any pressure. I was looking for a dead bush to practice on,” Adora explains. Catra’s words imply that there isn’t anyone else searching, which means that they are probably far enough away to have a private conversation, but speaking in the woods feels dangerous. Without walls encircling them, anyone could overhear. Still, it’s likely safer to talk here than in one of the bungalows back in Plumeria.

Catra pauses above her, her eyes roaming over Adora’s face. For a minute her expression is open, maybe even concerned, but the longer that Adora blinks up at her, the more suspicion seems to tinge her features. Her eyes stick on Adora’s chest. After a

second, Adora realizes why. She pulled back on her belt before coming back, but she forgot to fix her badge. Hastily, she reaches up and unpins it from the inside of her jacket, moving it to the outside where it is supposed to be. Catra pointedly raises an eyebrow at her.

"Adora. Where were you?" Catra asks, her tone as suspicious as it is anxious. Adora cringes a little, sheepish. She doesn't want to *lie* to Catra, and given that she needs her help to pull any of this off, she actually has to tell her as soon as possible, she is just nervous of being overheard. She glances to either side, causing Catra to scowl. "We're *alone*, Adora. I'd hear anyone coming long before you," she points out. Despite her condescending tone, the words make Adora relax a bit. She offers Catra a small, thankful smile.

"I wandered too far. I found the encampment that the fleeing Plumerians made and realized Princess Perfuma could probably help me with my magic," Adora explains, watching Catra's jaw fall open.

"*What?*" she hisses, her voice so high that it almost sounds like her tail has been stepped on. Adora hurriedly reaches up, covering Catra's mouth with her hand and glancing around, worried about the noise drawing attention. Catra growls, trying to pull back, but Adora uses her free hand to latch onto the back of her head and keep her mouth covered as she sends her a pleading look. Catra's claws dig into her shoulders, angry pinpricks on the edge of painful but not piercing her skin.

"You're going to get us caught," she responds, glancing around once more, but the only sound that she hears is the irritated swishing of Catra's tail lashing behind her. Catra narrows her eyes, her growl rising as she pointedly tries to bite Adora's palm. It doesn't work too well given their positions, but her teeth scraping on her palm make their point. Adora cringes a little as she lets her hands drop back to Catra's hips, holding her in place as she sends Catra a pleading look.

"What were you *thinking*?" Catra hisses, her voice quiet but the accusation in it no less cutting. Adora pouts a little, mostly because she knows very well that she wasn't thinking *much*. She was letting her heart rule her. She did what she thought was the right thing, but it certainly wasn't the smart choice. Smart would have been avoiding their enemy entirely or maybe eavesdropping on them for information – then again, that depends how you define "enemy", and Adora certainly wouldn't include Perfuma in that category after speaking to her.

"It worked, Catra. She taught me what to do. I can heal the tree," Adora assures her, squeezing her hands on her hips a little even though Catra is making no move to get up. Catra gapes at her again. Adora takes a deep breath, steeling herself. She isn't going to convince Catra that this isolated action was a good idea by itself – it would be considered treason within the Horde – but despite how Adora wasn't thinking through her actions at first, they are now part of a larger plan.

"Catra, Light Hope was right about the Horde. I can't *do* this. She-ra isn't meant to hurt people and I-" Adora cuts off, looking away as tears threaten to well up in her eyes. Above her, Catra's ears pin back. "I hate seeing people *running* from me. Being in Plumeria, talking to Perfuma… I can't fight for the Horde. I can't drive people from their homes," Adora tells her, her volume raising with her conviction. Ever since finding the sword, Adora has been scrambling.

She feels like she has finally found solid ground. Going against the Horde is the right thing to do and that is the only choice for Adora. Catra, however, looks a bit horrified. Her tail has stilled completely and her ears pinned back. Her eyes are wide as she just stares down at Adora. Her hands tighten on Adora's shoulders. Adora isn't sure if she is trying to hold her down or just angry. Adora swallows, shifting her hands up to cover Catra's own.

"Catra, I need to *stop* it before more innocent people get hurt. Please, help me. I can't 'wait and see' anymore. I need to take down Hordak. Taking over was your idea and I'll never manage it

without you," Adora begs, her tone pleading. She needs to do this. Talking with Perfuma was eye-opening. She didn't just teach Adora how to heal – in doing so, she showed Adora her mindset, and it wasn't one of a violent, dangerous tyrant.

"I'm only teaching you this because it can't be used to hurt people. Every person deserves healing, and when you show them kindness, they are more likely to put that back out into the world themselves. Maybe if the Horde can see what the world could be like, they'll change and we can go back to the way that things used to be," she told Adora as they stood in front of a bush with leaves that apparently *weren't* supposed to be brown. Her tone wasn't as open and loving as her words, but she was talking to her enemy, so it was earned.

The philosophy was so different than what Adora was used to. She realized in that moment that she had known she couldn't keep serving the Horde for a long time – maybe even since before she found the sword – but she has been pushing it down. The Horde can say that they are helping people, but civilians and even their own low rank soldiers suffer beneath them. Of all the people Adora knows, Catra can attest to that the most. Above Adora, her tail has begun to lash again as her eyes bore into Adora's. Adora swallows, squeezing Catra's hands gently.

"Catra, I've been *so lost*. I finally have a purpose now. I need to stand for this. I don't know how I'll live with myself if I don't. Please. We'll overthrow Hordak and… I don't know, make the Horde something better, or disband it, I didn't really get that far," Adora tries. She knows her argument kind of falls apart at the end, but Catra snorts, looking away with a small smile curling at the edge of her lip.

Her eyes are still burning with intensity, but her tail's lashes have slowed behind her. Her agitation has decreased a little, at least. Adora gives her a minute to process, gentling squeezing her hands and then lifting up to pet down her forearms soothingly. Adora doesn't know how long they can stay here unnoticed, but Catra already seems to be softening some. Adora knows her

words were shocking at first. It is something that takes time to settle in.

"You realize this is a terrible plan, right? That going against Hordak is just about the dumbest thing that we could do and that Light Hope is trying to manipulate you as much as Shadow Weaver was?" Catra asks, finally looking back to her. Her tone is bordering on scathing, but Adora still breaks into a wide grin, because for all the flaws in the plan, that is Catra saying *yes*.

"That's what you're here for," she returns. Catra gives an irritated huff, but it is mostly performative. She definitely still seems agitated as she sends Adora an unamused look, her tail whipping to one side and then the other, but Adora knows that she has made headway. She shifts her hands all the way back to Catra's hips, placing them there lightly before applying gentle pressure. She watches Catra's back straighten just a little at the touch.

In the few days that they have gotten to share a bed together, Adora has discovered that Catra loves being held despite how she likes to pretend otherwise. Maybe Adora is abusing that knowledge right now, but anything that helps Catra feel more settled is welcome. Adora knows that she is asking a lot of her. Going against the Horde isn't going to be easy or safe. Catra sighs, looking down at her for a long moment as she thinks.

"Adora, when I couldn't find you… If we do this, no more wandering off without me. We need to be on the same page or we're going to get caught in a lie – or an *ambush*. If this is what you need to do, fine, but you have to let me be a part of it too," Catra tells her, making pointed eye contact as she speaks. Adora swallows, worried about what she put Catra through when she woke up alone. She knows the things she would have worried about if Catra was the one missing. She quickly nods.

"I can do that. I need you for this, Catra," Adora returns. Catra's tail stills, her eyes getting a bit distant, but after a moment she sighs and nods, her tail dropping limp behind her.

"Okay. Okay, fine, but we have to be fucking *careful*," Catra agrees. Adora takes a deep breathe, releasing it and feeling tension seep out of her with it. They are beginning a new fight, but Adora is used to fighting in a war. What she isn't used to is fighting an internal battle like she has been for the last few days. Knowing that she is on the right path again brings peace with it. Adora reaches up, wrapping her arms around Catra's back and pulling her down to her chest and squeezing her in a tight hug.

Catra grumbles a little, but it isn't a true growl – or a true protest. She just has to do it for show even as she tucks her nose down into Adora's neck, breathing deeply. She clings to Adora just as tightly as Adora holds her. They both need this, but whatever new battle they are about to face, they're going to face it together.

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Catra isn't exactly thrilled about this turn of events, but if it keeps them together, she will do anything. She was never loyal to the Horde – they never did anything to *earn* her loyalty – but she is willing to kill for Adora. She might not be as invested in the rights or wrongs of this war as Adora is, but Adora wants them to fight it together, and that's enough for Catra. Adora said she couldn't do this alone. Adora says she *needs* her. Catra wants to be needed by her.

It's an acknowledgement of what she can do – or that she can do anything at all and isn't *worthless* like so many people have treated her. She has always been desperate to be treated like she deserves. She will gladly turn against her supposed masters to get that from Adora. Besides, she doesn't disagree with anything that Adora has said about the Horde. As long as Adora isn't expecting her to run off and join the Rebellion or start dressing in flouncy skirts like a princess, then Catra will help her even on a suicidal mission like overthrowing Hordak.

They always dreamed of ruling the Horde together. This is a version of that dream, even if Catra is pretty sure that they aren't going to be ruling over Etheria when this is all said and done. Their lives have been nerve-racking ever since Adora became second, but the quality of them has improved a lot and they still have Hordak above them. They don't need an entire military organization at their command to be secure.

Catra says yes for all these reasons, but the chief one is quite simple: she is more afraid of losing Adora than she is of retribution from Hordak. There is nothing that he could do to her that would be worse than that, and after pacing the woods wondering where Adora was, Catra is afraid that she couldn't talk Adora out of this. Adora gets determined and often there is no changing her mind. If Catra says no, it may very well send Adora running into the Rebellion's arms.

Catra wants to ask more questions about what the hell happened with Princess Perfuma and how Adora convinced her to teach her anything, but after Adora's obvious relief at Catra agreeing to help her, she pivots gears. She is set on healing the tree. She takes Catra's hand and leads her back to Plumeria with the kind of determination that would make you think every second she isn't healing the tree is a failure.

"Have you thought through how you're going to explain healing the tree to the soldiers at all?" Catra asks as they approach Plumeria again. With her voice this low, they shouldn't be overheard despite their proximity. Adora pauses midstride, placing her foot back on the ground and sending Catra a pleading look. Catra sighs. Yeah, she *definitely* needs Catra's help to pull this off. "Give me a minute to think," Catra tells her as she rolls her eyes.

By the time that they get back into the city, Catra has come up with the excuse. They talk to the base leader and tell him that they are going back to the Fright Zone after the next set of soldiers rise, which will have everyone up for the evening. Before they go back, however, they want to give a demonstration of She-ra's powers to the soldier – *since she didn't get to display them in*

*battle*, Catra lies smoothly – to inspire confidence in the next chapter of the Horde's domination.

Adora sends her looks that are far too fond to be shared in front of people as she sweettalks the base leader. Catra's tail twitches, but she manages to keep her face straight despite how it flusters her a little. She likes being looked at that way. It's reassuring, especially after the panic earlier in the day. Besides, she earned it. The excuse is better than anything that Adora would have come up with.

Within an hour, everyone is gathered around the Heart-Blossom for a "demonstration." Catra watches proudly from the back as Adora raises her sword in the air and summons She-ra. Adora hardly waits for the soldiers to take her in, walking forward to the tree and raising the sword up towards the tree. She points its tip at the runestone within the trunk. Catra's breath hitches when Adora starts glowing.

She-ra usually glows at least a little, but the golden light that wraps around her skin and whips through her hair now is different as light gathers at the tip of the sword and then a beam flies from it, hitting the runestone. The effect is instant, the tree almost seeming to breathe in as life pulses through it and leaves burst forth from the branches. As Adora maintains the beam, a wave of life seems to seep out from the roots of the tree, spreading across the ground.

Beneath Catra's feet, the grass thickens and small plants spring up. In the distance, the tree line turns lush, the bedraggled branches brightening just like the Heart-Blossom. The glowing dims and Catra looks back to find Adora lowering the sword, the golden beam gone. With the Heart-Blossom healed, a ripple effect seems to be spreading through the valley. Around Catra, the crowd murmurs and then breaks into applause. Catra herself feels breathless as Adora turns around and finally genuinely smiles at something that she has accomplished.

She raises a hand, giving a wave of acknowledgement to the crowd, and then a bow for good measure as they continue to cheer. She looked happy when Catra agreed to go along with her insane plan, but the happiness on her face now is more than just relief. The cheers are certainly helping, but as Adora's eyes search the crowd and stop on Catra's face, it is plain to see that it is deeper than that. She looks away quickly just to turn her head and marvel at how Plumeria has burst to life with joy sparkling in her eyes.

It is clear to see that bringing life back into Plumeria has breathed some back into Adora as well. As she walks down the hill, Catra can see a hopeful look in her eye. Catra doesn't necessarily believe in the cause, but she does believe in Adora. She doesn't know how – or *if* they can pull this off on their own – but she has been looking at an anxiety-ridden Adora for days, and if she gets to see her light up like this, this risky plan might just be worth it.

Chapter End Notes

Next up: a **skippable** ~intimate~ Interlude, Stolen Moments. There is no plot in this fic and you can skip over it if that's not your thing.
I plan to post the "Season One" fic notes after that interlude. I've talked about this on Tumblr, but the fic has two acts/parts in my head and I'm calling that Seasons for this one (these Seasons do not correspond to the actual show's seasons).
Next up (after the Interlude): System Overload.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!